Chapter 7. Blocking and Confounding in the 2^k Factorial Design

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1 Blocking a Replicated Design

- If there are n replicates of the 2^k design, each replicate can be run as a **block** (e.g. one batch of raw material, one day).
- Replicates are run in block order; runs *within* a block are randomized.

Example 7.1: Chemical process in three blocks

Block 1	Block 2	Block 3
$(1) = 28$	$(1) = 25$	$(1) = 27$
$a = 36$	$a = 32$	$a = 32$
$b = 18$	$b = 19$	$b = 23$
$ab = 31$	$ab = 30$	$ab = 29$
$B_1 = 113$	$B_2 = 106$	$B_3 = 111$

Without blocks (Ch. 6): $SS_A = \frac{1}{2^2 \cdot 3}(ab+a-b-(1))^2 = 208.33$, $A = \frac{1}{2\cdot 3}(ab+a-b-(1)) = 8.33$; error df $2^2(3-1) = 8$.
Treat the replicate as a block, exactly like the RCBD of Ch. 4, $y_{ij} = \mu + \tau_i + \beta_j + \varepsilon_{ij}$ with the $2^2 = 4$ treatment combinations as "treatments". In Ch. 4, $SS_{\text{Block}} = \sum_i \sum_j (\bar{y}_{\cdot j} - \bar{y}_{\cdot\cdot})^2 = \frac{1}{a}\sum_j y_{\cdot j}^2 - \frac{1}{N} y_{\cdot\cdot}^2$. Here each block has $2^2 = 4$ runs:

$$SS_{\text{Blocks}} = \frac{1}{4}\sum_{j=1}^{3} B_j^2 - \frac{1}{12} y_{\cdot\cdot}^2 = \frac{113^2 + 106^2 + 111^2}{4} - \frac{330^2}{12}$$
$$= \frac{36326}{4} - 9075 = 9081.5 - 9075 = 6.50, \qquad \text{df} = b - 1 = 2,$$

$SS_E = 31.34 - 6.50 = 24.84, \qquad \text{df} = 8 - 2 = 6.$

Source	SS	DF	MS	F_0
Blocks	6.50	2	3.25	
A	208.33	1	208.33	50.32
B	75.00	1	75.00	18.12
AB	8.33	1	8.33	2.01
Error	24.84	6	4.14	
Total	323.00	11		

Conclusions are unchanged (block effect is small); the effect estimates are identical because each block contains a full replicate.

2 Confounding in Blocks: the Unreplicated Case

When a full replicate cannot be run in one block (block size $< 2^k$), some effect information must be sacrificed: it becomes **confounded** (indistinguishable) with blocks. Usually a high-order interaction is chosen.

2.1 2^2 in two blocks

Block 1	Block 2
(1)	a
ab	b

Trt	I	A	B	AB	Block
(1)	+	−	−	+	1
a	+	+	−	−	2
b	+	−	+	−	2
ab	+	+	+	+	1

$A = \frac{1}{2}(ab + a - (1) - b)$ and $B = \frac{1}{2}(ab + b - (1) - a)$ are **unaffected by blocking**: each estimate has one plus and one minus treatment combination in each block. But $AB = \frac{1}{2}(ab + (1) - a - b) = \frac{1}{2}[(\text{block 1}) - (\text{block 2})]$ is **confounded with blocks**.

Formal argument. Add block effects δ_1, δ_2 to every observation in blocks 1 and 2. Then

$$\begin{aligned} \mathrm{E}(\text{Contrast}_A) &= \mathrm{E}[ab] + \mathrm{E}[a] - \mathrm{E}[(1)] - \mathrm{E}[b] \ \ni\ \delta_1 + \delta_2 - \delta_1 - \delta_2 = 0, \\ \mathrm{E}(\text{Contrast}_{AB}) &= \mathrm{E}[ab] + \mathrm{E}[(1)] - \mathrm{E}[a] - \mathrm{E}[b] \ \ni\ \delta_1 + \delta_1 - \delta_2 - \delta_2 = 2(\delta_1 - \delta_2) \neq 0. \end{aligned}$$

Thus the A and B contrasts are free of block effects, while the AB contrast estimates AB-interaction + block difference: they cannot be separated. ■

2.2 2^3 in two blocks with ABC confounded

Trt	I	A	B	AB	C	AC	BC	ABC	Block
(1)	+	−	−	+	−	+	+	−	1
a	+	+	−	−	−	−	+	+	2
b	+	−	+	−	−	+	−	+	2
ab	+	+	+	+	−	−	−	−	1
c	+	−	−	+	+	−	−	+	2
ac	+	+	−	−	+	+	−	−	1
bc	+	−	+	−	+	−	+	−	1
abc	+	+	+	+	+	+	+	+	2

Block 1 $= \{(1), ab, ac, bc\}$ (the $-$ signs of ABC), Block 2 $= \{a, b, c, abc\}$ (the $+$ signs). Every other column has two $+$ and two $-$ within each block (orthogonality), so all effects except ABC are estimated free of blocks.

3 Constructing the Blocks: the Defining Contrast

Definition 7.2: Defining contrast

$$L = \alpha_1 x_1 + \alpha_2 x_2 + \cdots + \alpha_k x_k,$$

$x_i \in \{0, 1\}$ is the level of the ith factor in a treatment combination, and $\alpha_i \in \{0, 1\}$ is the exponent of the ith factor in the effect to be confounded. Treatment combinations with the same $L \pmod 2$ go to the same block.

For ABC: $\alpha_1 = \alpha_2 = \alpha_3 = 1$, $L = x_1 + x_2 + x_3$.

Trt	L	mod 2
(1)	$0+0+0=0$	0
a	$1+0+0=1$	1
b	$0+1+0=1$	1
ab	$1+1+0=2$	0
c	$0+0+1=1$	1
ac	$1+0+1=2$	0
bc	$0+1+1=2$	0
abc	$1+1+1=3$	1

Block 1 ($L = 0$): $(1), ab, ac, bc$; Block 2 ($L = 1$): a, b, c, abc.

Remark 7.3: Why L works

The sign of a treatment combination in the column of effect $A^{\alpha_1}B^{\alpha_2}C^{\alpha_3}$ is $\prod_i (2x_i - 1)^{\alpha_i} = (-1)^{\sum_i \alpha_i (1 - x_i)}$, which depends only on $\sum \alpha_i x_i \pmod 2$ (for fixed α). So $L \bmod 2$ splits the runs exactly by the sign of the confounded column.

3.1 The principal block and group structure

- The **principal block** is the block containing (1).

- The principal block is a *group* under multiplication mod 2 (exponents mod 2): any element except (1) can be generated by multiplying two other elements of the principal block. For ABC confounded:

$$ab \cdot bc = ab^2c = ac, \qquad ab \cdot ac = a^2bc = bc, \qquad bc \cdot ac = abc^2 = ab.$$

- The other block is a coset: multiply one element of the new block by every element of the principal block. Since b is in the other block:

$$b \cdot (1) = b, \quad b \cdot ab = ab^2 = a, \quad b \cdot ac = abc, \quad b \cdot bc = b^2c = c.$$

Closure. If $L(u) \equiv 0$ and $L(v) \equiv 0$, then for the product uv (exponents added mod 2) $L(uv) \equiv L(u) + L(v) \equiv 0$, because L is linear mod 2. Similarly if $L(w) \equiv 1$ then $L(wu) \equiv 1$ for every u in the principal block. ■

3.2 More blocks (four blocks)

To run a 2^k in 2^p blocks choose p independent effects to confound; their **generalized interactions** (products mod 2) are automatically confounded too. E.g. a 2^3 in 4 blocks confounding AB and AC also confounds $AB \cdot AC = A^2BC = BC$: $3 = 2^2 - 1$ effects are lost (one per block df). Blocks are formed by the pairs $(L_1, L_2) = (x_1 + x_2,\, x_1 + x_3)$ mod 2: $(0,0) : \{(1), abc\}$, $(1,1) : \{a, bc\}$, $(1,0) : \{b, ac\}$, $(0,1) : \{c, ab\}$.

4 Block Confounding with Replication

4.1 Complete confounding

The same effect is confounded in every replicate. 2^3 in two blocks, three replicates, ABC confounded in all:

Rep 1		Rep 2		Rep 3	
Bl 1	Bl 2	Bl 1	Bl 2	Bl 1	Bl 2
(1)	a	ac	a	c	(1)
ab	b	(1)	c	abc	ac
ac	c	ab	abc	b	bc
bc	abc	bc	b	a	ab

(Block labels within a replicate are arbitrary; each replicate splits $\{(1), ab, ac, bc\}$ vs $\{a, b, c, abc\}$, and the assignment of runs within blocks is randomized.)

Source	DF
Replications	2
Blocks (or ABC)	1
Replication × blocks	2
A, B, AB, C, AC, BC	1 each (6)
Error (replication × all other effects)	12
Total	23

The 6 block df ($= 2 \cdot 3$ blocks $-1 = 5$) split as 2 (replicates) +1 (ABC/blocks) +2 (rep × blocks); the error df $= 3 \cdot 6 - 6 = 12$ are the replicate × effect interactions for the six estimable effects. ABC cannot be tested.

4.2 Partial confounding

Confound a *different* interaction in each replicate, so information on every interaction is retained from the replicates where it is not confounded. 2^3, four replicates, confounding ABC, AB, AC, BC in replicates 1–4:

Rep 1 (ABC)		Rep 2 (AB)		Rep 3 (AC)		Rep 4 (BC)	
Bl 1	Bl 2	Bl 1	Bl 2	Bl 1	Bl 2	Bl 1	Bl 2
(1)	a	(1)	a	(1)	a	(1)	b
ab	b	c	b	b	c	a	c
ac	c	ab	ac	ac	ab	bc	ab
bc	abc	abc	bc	abc	bc	abc	ac

(Check rep 2 with $L = x_1 + x_2$: $(1), c, ab, abc$ have $L \equiv 0$.)

Source	DF
Replications	3
Blocks within replications	4
ABC (rep 1), AB (rep 2), AC (rep 3), BC (rep 4)	1 each
A, B, C	1 each
AB (from reps 1,3,4), AC (reps 1,2,4), BC (reps 1,2,3), ABC (reps 2,3,4)	1 each
Error	17
Total	31

DF check: $31 = 3 + 4 + 7 + 17$. Each partially confounded interaction is estimated from the 3 replicates in which it is unconfounded, so its SS is $(\text{Contrast}^{(3\text{ reps})})^2/(3 \cdot 2^3)$ and it has relative information 3/4.

Example 7.4: Final 2025 style — ABC in rep 1, AB in rep 2, BC in rep 3

(a) *Blocks.* Rep 1 ($L = x_1 + x_2 + x_3$): $\{(1), ab, ac, bc\} \,|\, \{a, b, c, abc\}$. Rep 2 ($L = x_1 + x_2$): $\{(1), c, ab, abc\} \,|\, \{a, b, ac, bc\}$. Rep 3 ($L = x_2 + x_3$): $\{(1), a, bc, abc\} \,|\, \{b, c, ab, ac\}$.
(b) *ANOVA skeleton* ($N = 24$):

Source	DF
Replications	2
Blocks within replications (ABC rep 1, AB rep 2, BC rep 3)	3
A, B, C, AC (never confounded)	1 each (4)
AB (reps 1, 3), BC (reps 1, 2), ABC (reps 2, 3)	1 each (3)
Error	11
Total	23

Error df $= 23 - 2 - 3 - 7 = 11$.